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grown considerably. The studies published till date do not demonstrate a raised risk within approximately ten years of use for any tumour of the brain or head. However, some key problems remain—for example, selective non-response and exposure misclassification.

The available data does not suggest a causal association between the use of mobile phones and fast-growing tumours such as malignant glioma in adults. For slow-growing tumours such as meningioma and acoustic neuroma, as well as for glioma among long-term users, the absence of associations reported thus far is less conclusive because the current observation period is still too short. Currently, the data completely lacks the potential carcinogenic effect of exposures in childhood and adolescence.

Several precautions are suggested for cellphone users:

1. Minimise the time you speak. Preferably use the mobile phone only for a very short duration.
2. Minimise the intensity of the irradiation. Avoid calling when the signal is weak, because then the mobile radiates maximally. Keep your phone as far away from your body as possible. For this purpose:
 - (i) Use safe headsets—the kind with a plastic tube between the earpiece and the phone. Search Google for tube + headset (or airtube) and you will find several alternatives.
 - (ii) Use a loudspeaker phone, as your headset may not always be available. But be careful that your face is as far away from the phone as possible to reduce absorption of radiation by the face.
3. Avoid putting the cellphone in your left pocket, which is closer to heart.
4. Avoid carrying cellphone clipped to your belt, as it has been found to affect fertility.
5. Use a rear shield for the phone to prevent radiation towards your body.
6. Buy cellphones with low SAR rating.
7. Buy cellphones of reputed make so that at least the present-day power levels are ensured.
8. Keep the cellphone away while sleeping.
9. Switch between the left and right side of your head when using the cellphone without headsets.
10. Pregnant women should avoid cellphone usage as it may affect the foetus.
11. More precautions should be taken with children since they are more susceptible to cell damage.
12. Avoid unwanted calls and advertisements through calls.
13. Use your landline, particularly when your work demands a lot of communication. ●

The author is retired DGM, Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)